protection in the embassy would further complicate the situation politically. India may never be able to build strong relations with the Mujahideen on a fresh note. Dixit could not voice this dilemma openly.[17] There were many in India who wanted to give Najibullah asylum on the grounds that he was just 44 years old with political constituencies among Pashtun communities, and argued that giving up on him would imply capitulating to the Mujahideen. Najibullah himself had ealier confided to Nambiar that he might be able to influence Afghan politics, however limitedly, from outside Afghanistan more than from the inside, in face of the Soviet disintegration.[18] The remaining secular and nationalist elements of the *Hizb-e-Watan*, it was calculated, would remain in Afghanistan and be represented in a coalition government that the UN was trying to cobble together. However, there were others in India who argued that giving Najibullah asylum would further antagonise the Mujahideen leadership, something that India should avoid. The assumption was that once the anger settled, the Mujahideen would not throw away a beneficial relationship with India.

Caught in an awkward situation, India remained non-committal till the UN Secretary General Boutros Boutros-Ghali paid an unscheduled visit to New Delhi on 22 April 1992. Boutros-Ghali's sole aim was to push Rao into taking initiative and exfiltrating Najibullah from Kabul (despite the UN's abortive attempt) and give him asylum in India. After six days of deliberation on Boutros-Ghali's request, which included detailed talks about possible options between Najibullah and Nambiar, home minister S. B. Chavan publicly announced that India would be willing to shelter Najibullah 'if he so desires'.[19] Playing upon a situation where Najibullah's 'desire' was the last element that would have helped his cause either politically or personally, the statement reeked of political caution.

Adding insult to injury, on 4 May 1992, when Indian parliamentarians asked about India's talks with Boutros-Ghali and its decision to host Najibullah, minister-of-state for external affairs, Eduardo Faleiro, informed that despite the general feelers for asylum from Najibullah, 'the government are not aware of any decision taken by the United Nations in this regard, and the question [of Najibullah] is hypothetical as no such request has so far been received'.[20] When pushed as to what exactly would the government's stand be if such a formal request were to come, Rao and Faleiro balked. 'As and when we get some specific